

ANI

AYODHYA

ON TRACK
UP chief minister Yogi Adityanath inspecting the railway station in Ayodhya ahead of its inauguration

PILGRIMAGE TOURISM HAS TAKEN OFF, AND AYODHYA'S REVENUE GRAPH MAY SOON START RESEMBLING THE MOUNT MERU OF ANCIENT MYTH. THE WHOLE REGION COULD BLOOM

says sales have quadrupled and is hopeful that "year-round pilgrims" will end her financial insecurity.

Iqbal Ansari cherishes another kind of closure. One of the main litigants in the Ram Janmabhoomi-Babri Masjid land suit, he lives a few metres away from the temple and carries memories that he would rather not. Some of the darkest and most disruptive episodes of modern India had radiated out like tectonic convulsions from this epicentre, and he is happy it's all past. And he'll settle for the new masjid that's due to come up in Dhannipur village, about 25 km away from town. Only problem there is that, besides grand designs splashed across newspapers, nothing has moved in the four years since the Supreme Court ordered that five acres be given for an alternate place of worship to compensate for the loss of Babri Masjid. Reports speak of goats grazing on the allotted land, and only a signboard adorns the site, with the words: "A Masterpiece in Making: Masjid Muhammad Bin Abdullah." Even that name came after a bit of wrangling over the one proposed first: Masjid-e-Ayodhya. When the masterpiece does materialise, that can conceivably only contribute to the influx at the new airport and railway station.

Altogether, an extraordinary metamorphosis for a town that has seen a few in the past. Including being one of India's first historic urban centres in the post-Harappan age—it was called Saketa those days, a city with a strong Buddhist imprint if anything, whose loose identification with the Ayodhya of the Rama story seems to have been fully concretised only by the end of the Gupta period. The final recensions of Valmiki's Ramayana, clearly done at a historical juncture when there are already Yavanas (Ionian Greeks) on the far western frontiers, place the site firmly on the banks of the modern Sarayu. But the river's name itself seems to flow across geographies: from a Rigvedic Sarayu, often identified with the Avestan Harayu, in Afghanistan. The human inclination is such that places themselves travel. Thus, a river called Serayu in Java—and an Ayuthhaya in Thailand. Back in the present, the town in Uttar Pradesh, an early entrant into the Iron Age, has been late on the modern game. Its peers on the *moksha-puri* pantheon of places have been soaking in the general explosion of pilgrimage tourism in recent decades, dispensing salvation to hundreds of millions. Haridwar in neighbouring Uttarakhand, with a population of 2.5 million now, had footfalls crossing 21 million by 2019, with an ebb and flow governed by events on the holy calendar, like the Kumbh. Varanasi's 2 million inhabitants hosted 72 million visitors in 2022. Footfalls anywhere close to that and Ayodhya could see its tourism revenue graph start resembling the Mount Meru of ancient myth. Nor will it be a lone peak. What everyone envisages is an entire regional sector in bloom, with Ayodhya-Kashi-Prayagraj-Chitrakoot forming a circuit. With the middle class's mobility soaring as much as its piety, Kosala is striking while the iron is red-hot.

AYODHYA PURANA

Ayodhya was not built in a day. None of its incarnations, in fact, present or past. The most primeval one is an Ayodhya of the mind—itself a mutable thing that has seen many transformations over millennia, anticipating and modelling a city. Now that mental map is changing again. The city of Ayodhya is authoring a new purana about itself, one that's hopefully less sanguinary than the immediately preceding one. What does the draft outline? An ambition to refashion the city as